# The Sound of Music

## The big idea

This chapter has two parts about musicians who overcame obstacles. **Part I** (by Deborah Cowley) is about **Evelyn Glennie**, a Scottish percussionist who became profoundly deaf yet became a world-class musician. **Part II** is about **Ustad Bismillah Khan**, who made the **shehnai** a classical instrument and loved India deeply.

## Part I: Evelyn Glennie – listening without hearing

- Her hearing loss was noticed when she was about **eight**; by **eleven** she was **profoundly deaf**. A specialist advised hearing aids and a school for the deaf.
- At school, percussionist **Ron Forbes** noticed her potential. He tuned two large drums to different notes and asked her to feel the sound. She discovered she could sense **higher notes in the upper body and lower notes in the legs**.
- She auditioned for the **Royal Academy of Music, London**, was accepted and scored some of the highest marks in its history.
- She performs **barefoot** to feel vibrations through the floor, and plays about a thousand instruments. She also gives free concerts in hospitals and prisons and was named **Soloist of the Year (Royal Philharmonic Society, 1991)**.
- She inspires deaf children, showing that a disability need not stop you.

**EVELYN'S MESSAGE**

Hard work and determination can turn a disability into a different ability. "If you work hard and know where you are going, you'll get there."

## Part II: Bismillah Khan – the shehnai of India

- **Origin of the shehnai:** Emperor **Aurangzeb** banned the shrill **pungi** in the royal residence. A barber from a family of musicians improved it, using a hollow, longer, broader pipe with holes. Because it was first played in the **Shah's chamber** by a **nai** (barber), it was called the **shehnai**. It became an auspicious instrument at weddings and temples.
- Bismillah Khan was born on **21 March 1916** at **Dumraon, Bihar**. His grandfather **Rasool Bux Khan** played the shehnai for the king of Bhojpur.
- He learnt from his uncle **Ali Bux**, practised at the **Balaji and Mangala Maiya temples** and on the banks of the **Ganga** in Benaras, which inspired him to create new ragas.
- He joined **All India Radio, Lucknow, in 1938**.
- On **15 August 1947** he played from the **Red Fort**, the first Indian to greet independent India with his shehnai (Raag Kafi).
- He played in films (*Gunj Uthi Shehnai*) but disliked film-world artificiality. He was the first Indian invited to the **Lincoln Center Hall, USA**, and an auditorium in **Tehran** was named after him.
- He received the **Padma Shri, Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan** and the **Bharat Ratna (2001)**.
- When a student asked him to settle in the USA, he refused: he could not take the **Ganga** and **Benaras/Dumraon** with him.

**WHO NAMED THE SHEHNAI?**

It was not Bismillah Khan. The name came centuries earlier, from "shah" + "nai" in Aurangzeb's time.

## Themes and values

- **Determination** against odds (Evelyn's deafness, Bismillah's modest start).
- **Dedication and practice**.

- **Patriotism and secularism**: a Muslim musician who practised in temples and loved Benaras.
- **Humility and simplicity** despite fame.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Evelyn learn to "hear" music? How was the shehnai transformed? Why did Bismillah Khan refuse to settle in the USA? What qualities do the two musicians share? Value points: perseverance, passion, rootedness, inspiration to others.

## Quick recap

- Evelyn Glennie: deaf by 11, Ron Forbes, Royal Academy of Music, plays barefoot.
- Bismillah Khan: born 1916 Dumraon, AIR 1938, Red Fort 1947, Bharat Ratna 2001.
- Shehnai = played in the Shah's chamber by a nai.

## Practice questions

1. Who helped Evelyn Glennie sense music through her body?
   (a) Her mother (b) Ron Forbes (c) A hearing specialist (d) Ali Bux
2. By what age had Evelyn become profoundly deaf?
   (a) Five (b) Eight (c) Eleven (d) Sixteen
3. Why did Aurangzeb ban the pungi?
   (a) It was made of gold (b) It was a foreign instrument (c) It needed too many players (d) Its sound was shrill and unpleasant
4. Bismillah Khan was born in
   (a) Benaras, Uttar Pradesh (b) Dumraon, Bihar (c) Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh (d) Bhojpur, Bihar
5. On 15 August 1947, Bismillah Khan
   (a) received the Bharat Ratna (b) joined All India Radio (c) played the shehnai from the Red Fort (d) performed at the Lincoln Center
6. Why did Bismillah Khan refuse to settle in the USA?
   (a) He disliked travelling (b) The pay was too low (c) He could not take the Ganga and his beloved Benaras along (d) He was not allowed a visa
7. How was the pungi transformed into the shehnai?
8. Evelyn Glennie and Bismillah Khan both achieved greatness through dedication. Compare the qualities that made them successful.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. b 5. c 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes